Haligric Research Integration Series

People of the Root and the Rising Water

A COMPLETE DEEP DIVE

The Sacred Traditions of the Shoshone, Paiute, Ute, Nez Perce, and Columbia Plateau Nations

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Between the Sierra Nevada and the Rockies, and along the great salmon rivers of the Columbia Plateau, a different kind of sacred world took shape — one with no priesthood, built instead on ordinary people who are unexpectedly called by spirits to heal.

Here Salmon offered itself first, before any other food, so that people could live. Here a Paiute man named Wovoka fell into a vision during a solar eclipse and gave the whole western half of a continent a dance meant to bring back the dead and end the suffering — a dance that ended, instead, in a massacre at a place called Wounded Knee.

This is a religion of root digging and berry gathering treated as sacrament, of tutelary spirits who choose their healers rather than the other way around.

And it is, right now, a religion whose central rite — a salmon returning up its home river — is caught in a federal court fight that changed direction twice in the last two years alone.

Contents

Introduction — People of the Root and the Rising Water....3
Origins and Cosmology....4
Shamanism and Spirit Power....5
The First Salmon Ceremony....6
The Ghost Dance — Wovoka's Prophecy....7
Key Figures....8
Self-Care, Wellness, and Daily Practice....9
Legacy and Influence....10
Salmon, Water, and Broken Promises — Controversies and Fairness....11

Introduction — People of the Root and the Rising Water

The Great Basin — the vast, arid interior between the Sierra Nevada and the Rocky Mountains — is home to the Numic-speaking Western Shoshone, Northern and Southern Paiute, and Ute nations, whose traditional life centered on small, mobile family bands adapted to a demanding desert environment through extensive knowledge of seasonal plant and animal resources. To the north and west, the Columbia Plateau nations — the Nez Perce (Niimíipuu), Yakama, Umatilla, Warm Springs, Spokane, and related Sahaptin- and Salish-speaking peoples — built their spiritual and material life instead around the great salmon runs of the Columbia and Snake River systems.

Though linguistically and culturally distinct, these neighboring regions share overlapping ceremonial and spiritual patterns — individually acquired spirit power, shamanic healing, root and salmon first-fruits rites, and, in the case of the Ghost Dance, a shared prophetic movement that began in the Great Basin and spread across the entire Plateau and Plains.

Origins and Cosmology

Great Basin cosmology is built around a cycle of myths featuring anthropomorphic animal progenitors — chiefly Wolf, Coyote, Rabbit, Bear, and Mountain Lion — credited with shaping the present landscape, establishing the region's plant and animal resources, and setting the customs and social rules that govern human life. Coyote in particular functions as both culture hero and trickster, responsible for both valuable gifts to humanity and for the mistakes and misfortunes that explain the world's imperfections.

Most Numic peoples hold a dualistic concept of the soul: one component tied to basic vitality and continued life, the other a dreaming or wandering self vulnerable to loss during sleep or illness — a concept structurally similar to, though independently developed from, soul theories found elsewhere in North America, including among the Inuit.

Shamanism and Spirit Power

Shamanism is close to universal across Great Basin societies, and unusually for North America, both men and women became shamans, typically after receiving an unsought spiritual calling rather than through deliberate apprenticeship. A shaman's power derived from a tutelary spirit-guide who instructed them in healing techniques and ritual performance, and healing ceremonies — which could extend across multiple days and involve the patient's extended family — commonly employed the widespread North American practice of ritually extracting a disease-causing object from the patient's body, understood as the physical source of the illness.

The Eastern Shoshone, in a documented instance of cross-cultural exchange with Plains neighbors, adopted the vision quest as an additional means of acquiring spiritual power, illustrating the porous boundary between Great Basin and Plains ceremonial practice. Spirit-beings inhabiting the landscape were understood in both benevolent and dangerous forms — water babies, for instance, were widely described as luring people to their deaths in springs and lakes, a cautionary figure invoked much as the Inuit Qallupilluit are used to keep children from dangerous ice.

The First Salmon Ceremony

Among the Columbia Plateau nations, the First Salmon Feast is a mandatory ceremonial rite that must be held before any commercial or subsistence salmon fishing season begins. Tribal tradition holds that when the Creator prepared to bring humans into the world, Salmon was the very first being to come forward and offer itself as food so that people could live, with Water following as the second such gift — an origin that establishes both as deserving of special ceremonial honor above other foods.

The ceremony takes place in a longhouse, with women and men forming separate lines along the south and north walls respectively, standing shoulder to shoulder as drummers lead prayer songs and a longhouse leader marks the ceremony's stages with a hand bell; participants sing and move in small, dignified steps expressing gratitude to the salmon and reaffirming traditional law. Water is blessed and drunk first, followed by the blessing and communal eating of salmon and other foods, and the rite concludes with a final water blessing. Plateau elders teach that salmon, deer, and elk are understood as brothers, and roots and berries as sisters, to be treated with the same respect owed to human kin — a relational theology that directly underlies the contemporary legal and political fight over salmon-bearing rivers described below.

The Ghost Dance — Wovoka's Prophecy

On January 1, 1889, during a solar eclipse in Nevada's Mason Valley, the Northern Paiute spiritual leader Wovoka (also known by his adopted name, Jack Wilson) experienced a vision in which he was taken to a heavenly realm, met God and deceased ancestors, and was instructed to teach his people a sacred dance to bring about peace and, ultimately, reunion with the dead and restoration of a world unspoiled by settler encroachment. Wovoka, orphaned as a teenager and raised for a time by a white ranching family before returning to his Paiute community, had already been known locally for shamanic healing before this vision propelled him to much wider prominence.

The dance itself was a demanding, marathon rite: five days of ceremony, with participants dancing for four consecutive nights and a final dance at dawn on the fifth day, followed by ritual bathing in a nearby river, with Wovoka envisioning the ceremony repeated in six-week cycles accompanied by communal feasting. The movement blended traditional Numic and broader Indigenous ritual elements with Christian theological language, and spread with remarkable speed to the Arapaho, Cheyenne, and Lakota Sioux, each nation adapting the core rite to its own theological framework while largely retaining Wovoka's original emphasis on nonviolence and right living.

Among the Lakota, the movement took on a more urgent, millenarian cast, with some practitioners believing the dance and its associated 'ghost shirts' would hasten an end to settler presence and provide supernatural protection to wearers. Federal Indian agents, alarmed by the movement's scale and its Lakota interpretation, placed Ghost Dance leaders on watch lists in late 1890; the resulting tension culminated on December 29, 1890, at Wounded Knee Creek, South Dakota, when U.S. Army troops, attempting to disarm a Lakota encampment, opened fire after a disputed gunshot, killing hundreds of Lakota men, women, and children in what is remembered as the Wounded Knee Massacre — an event that effectively ended the Ghost Dance as a mass movement, though modified forms of the practice persisted quietly into the twentieth century.

Key Figures

Wovoka, the Northern Paiute prophet whose 1889 vision launched the Ghost Dance movement, continued to live quietly in Mason Valley, Nevada, after the movement's collapse following Wounded Knee, maintaining his spiritual convictions until his death in 1932.

Sarah Winnemucca (Thocmetony), a Northern Paiute author, educator, and activist of the same generation, became one of the first Native American women to publish an autobiography in English (Life Among the Piutes, 1883) and worked extensively, through lecture tours and direct advocacy in Washington, to expose the mistreatment of Paiute communities by federal agents and settlers, becoming one of the most significant Indigenous voices of the era.

Chief Joseph (In-mut-too-yah-lat-lat) of the Nez Perce led his band's celebrated 1877 attempted flight toward Canada rather than accept forced relocation to a reduced reservation, a 1,170-mile fighting retreat that ended just short of the Canadian border and is remembered as one of the most skillfully conducted retreats in American military history, alongside his later, widely quoted advocacy for justice and honesty in the federal government's dealings with his people.

Self-Care, Wellness, and Daily Practice

Seasonal root and berry gathering — including bitterroot, camas, and huckleberry harvests central to Plateau subsistence — carries ceremonial as well as practical weight, opened in many communities by first-fruits blessings structurally similar to the First Salmon Feast, reinforcing the same theology of foods as kin deserving of thanks and respect rather than resources to be simply taken.

Sweat lodge purification is practiced across both Great Basin and Plateau communities for physical and spiritual cleansing, often preceding or following significant ceremonial or hunting activity, and shamanic healing rites — involving family participation, ritual song, and the extraction of disease-causing objects described earlier — remain part of contemporary Indigenous health practice in the region, frequently used alongside, rather than instead of, conventional medical care through tribal health service programs.

Legacy and Influence

The Ghost Dance movement, despite its violent suppression at Wounded Knee, is recognized as one of the most historically significant pan-Indigenous religious movements in North American history, and its example — a prophetic, ceremonial response to catastrophic cultural loss — is frequently cited alongside later revitalization movements, including the peyote-based Native American Church and the diffusion of the Plains Sun Dance into Great Basin communities during the twentieth century, both of which blend Indigenous and Christian elements in ways that echo Wovoka's original synthesis.

Sarah Winnemucca's autobiography remains a foundational text in Native American literature and continues to be taught as one of the earliest sustained first-person Indigenous accounts of federal Indian policy's human costs, while Chief Joseph's 1877 retreat and subsequent advocacy remain widely referenced touchstones in American historical memory of Indigenous resistance and eloquence.

Salmon, Water, and Broken Promises — Controversies and Fairness

Columbia Plateau nations' salmon-centered religious and subsistence practice is directly threatened by the four Lower Snake River dams, which have contributed to sharp declines in salmon populations that tribes describe as approaching extinction. In December 2023, following nearly three decades of litigation, the Biden administration announced the Columbia Basin Initiative, a historic agreement with the Nez Perce, Yakama, Umatilla, and Warm Springs nations committing over $500 million in federal funding, a five-year pause on litigation, and formal federal acknowledgment of the dams' profound harm to tribal treaty rights and ways of life, while leaving the ultimate question of dam breaching to future Congressional action.

In June 2025, the Trump administration unilaterally withdrew from this agreement, reversing the federal government's prior commitments; tribal nations and environmental legal organizations, including Earthjustice, condemned the withdrawal, and by early 2026 the paused litigation had formally resumed, with a federal judge ordering interim protective measures for Columbia River salmon in February 2026 while the underlying legal dispute continues. As of this writing, the fate of the Lower Snake River dams — and with it, the long-term viability of the ceremonial and subsistence relationship at the center of Plateau religious life — remains an open, actively litigated question rather than a settled one.

Closing

The First Salmon Feast is still held every spring on the Columbia Plateau, even as the rivers that make it possible remain the subject of active litigation between the tribes and the federal government.

The Ghost Dance's promise of return was never fulfilled the way Wovoka described it, but its logic — that ceremony can answer catastrophe — runs through everything that came after it in this region, root feast to sweat lodge to courtroom.

Grand rising to the people of the root and the rising water — the fight to keep the river's promise is still being argued, this year, in federal court.